

The Gesture of Protruding Tongue in Ancient Egypt: Significance, meaning and purpose

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إيماءة اللسان البارز في مصر القديمة: الدلالة والمعنى والهدف

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Abstract:

The protruding tongue is a multifaceted gesture that has been observed in diverse cultural contexts and historical periods. In contemporary societies, it can be interpreted in a multitude of ways. It can signify a lack of respect, mischievousness, playfulness, insult, and concentration. However, in certain cultures, extending the tongue out is a gesture of greeting and respect.

In ancient Egypt, the protruding tongue is represented in different contexts and is essentially associated with certain demons and gods, including the most well-known Bes, the great Cat of Heliopolis, Re cutting off the head of Apophis, Taweret, Ammit, as well as some guardians of the gates and demons of the underworld. Conversely, instances of the protruding tongue in representations of human figures are scarce, even in the most violent contexts. The protruding tongue has been likened to arrows and knives. Moreover, textual instances have been recorded where individuals or deities in Ancient Egypt were insulted, mocked, or threatened by a protruding tongue, as texts of Kamose describe the hostile stance of the Hyksos towards the Egyptians by this gesture. The protruding tongue is a common occurrence in the animal kingdom, particularly during slaughtering, hunting, and birth. In these instances, the tongue may serve to represent the animal's panic, pain, and vocalizations. The representation of animal heads with protruding tongues is a recurring motif in offering scenes. This paper will present an analysis and examination of the significance, meaning, and contexts of the protruding tongue in ancient Egyptian written, visual, and material sources.

Key words: protruding tongue, gestures, non-verbal communication, licking, mockery, provocation, arrows, protection

الملخص: تُعدّ إيماءة اللسان البارز واحدة من أهم الإيماءات المسجلة في سياقات ثقافية وعصور تاريخية متنوعة. في المجتمعات المعاصرة، يُمكن تفسير هذا الفعل بطرق متعددة. فقد يدل على عدم الاحترام، أو العبث، أو المزاح، أو الإهانة، أو التركيز، أو حتى الاستفزاز الجنسي. ومع ذلك، في بعض الثقافات، مثل التبت، يُستخدم إخراج اللسان كإشارة تحية واحترام.

في مصر القديمة، يُمثل بروز اللسان في سياقات مختلفة ويتخذ أشكالاً متنوعة. ترتبط هذه الإشارة أساساً ببعض الشياطين والآلهة، بما في ذلك أشهرها بس، قط هليوبوليس العظيم، رع الذي قطع رأس ثعبان أبوفيس، تاورت، عمممت، بالإضافة إلى بعض حراس بوابات وشياطين العالم السفلي. على العكس من ذلك، نادرًا ما نجد اللسان البارز في تمثيلات الشخصيات البشرية، حتى في أكثر السياقات عنفًا. ومن التمثيلات الجديرة بالذكر مناظر نادرة من صندوق توت عنخ آمون تمثل الأعداء بلسان بارز. علاوة على ذلك، تم تشبيه اللسان البارز بالسهام والساكين، وسُجّلت أمثلة نصية لأشخاص أو آلهة في مصر القديمة تعرضوا للإهانة أو السخرية أو التهديد عن طريق اللسان بارز، حيث تصف نصوص كاموس الموقف العدائي للهكسوس تجاه المصريين بهذه الإيماءة. يُعدّ اللسان البارز أمرًا شائعًا في عالم الحيوان، وخاصةً في مشاهد الذبح والصيد والولادة. في هذه الحالات، قد يُستخدم اللسان لتمثيل دعر الحيوان وألمه وأصواته. إضافة إلى ذلك، يُعدّ تمثيل رؤوس حيوانات الأضاحي بألسنتها البارزة عنصرًا متكررًا في مشاهد القربان. ستُقدم هذه الدراسة تحليلًا ودراسة لأهمية ومعنى وسياقات بروز اللسان في المصادر المصرية القديمة النصية والتصويرية والمادية.

الكلمات الدالة: اللسان البارز، الإيماءات، التواصل غير اللفظي، اللعق، السخرية، الاستفزاز، السهام، الحماية.

I. Introduction

In ancient Egypt, gestures and body language played a crucial role as visual human communication that requires no words to consciously convey specific meanings and messages, and symbolism to the observer. Iconography and texts in Ancient Egypt encompass various bodily gestures, including those of the hands, feet, and even the posture of the whole body. These gestures were not only an expression of emotions, but also of power, status, and specific functions. In this sense, they convey social values, religious beliefs, and the nature of some living creatures as a visual language and a non-complicated means of communication. However, their purpose and symbolism depend primarily on context, and therefore, they are culture-specific and occasionally vary across societies and time. Various gestures were deliberate actions that serve a specific symbolism and meaning in a particular context. This paper examines one of the highly significant gestures in Ancient Egyptian sources, namely the protruding tongue, which encompasses a broad spectrum of meanings, from mockery and defiance to intimidation, pain and protection. This study will be conducted by applying an interdisciplinary approach including an iconographic Analysis by investigating representations and sculptures of the protruding tongue to detect the recurrence of the gesture and its contexts. Furthermore, a linguistic correlation will be clarified by studying the Ancient Egyptian textual evidence mentioning the gesture for verbal explanations. Moreover, a comparison will be made to examine the continuity or transformation of the gesture in later periods or related/neighboring cultures. Studying and analyzing the nuances associated with this gesture enhances our understanding of the diverse ways in which the Ancient Egyptians communicated non-verbally, as the protruding tongue remains a remarkable topic for cultural and social exploration.

II. Research questions and methodology

In order to improve the understanding of the expression (interaction) of the protruding tongue in divine, human, and animal contexts in ancient Egypt, this study attempts to answer the following questions:

- How was the term “protruding tongue” defined in the ancient Egyptian language?
- What are the earliest iconographic and textual references to the protruding tongue in ancient Egypt?
- In what contexts is the protruding tongue evidenced?
- Was the protruding tongue considered a positive or negative facial expression?
- How and why did the protruding tongue reflect both human and animal behavior (therapeutic, hostile, protective, threatening, etc.)?

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- What is the cultural and symbolic significance of the protruding tongue gesture in ancient Egyptian art, texts, and rituals?
- Were depictions of the protruding tongue essentially symbolic or a representation of actual behavior observed by the ancient Egyptians in their environment?

As there is currently no study devoted exclusively to the protruding tongue in ancient Egypt, there is an urgent need for specific research on this topic to fill this gap in the study of ancient Egyptian gestures in both every day and religious contexts. Therefore, the main objective of this research project is to investigate and analyze the contextual, functional, symbolic, and communicative meaning of the gesture of the protruding tongue in ancient Egyptian iconography, rituals, and texts throughout ancient Egyptian history. In order to find answers to the research questions, this study carries an interdisciplinary approach combining Egyptology, art history, religious studies, and linguistics to analyze ancient Egyptian representations and texts and examine the cultural meanings and symbolism of the protruding tongue as intercultural nonverbal communication.

III. Terms of the tongue and the protruding tongue in Ancient Egyptian language

According to the ancient Egyptians' belief that thoughts are “formed” in the heart (the center of thoughts) and “realized” by uttering aloud, and thus, the heart and tongue become organs of creation for the creator god¹. As part of the deification of limbs, the tongue of the deceased is placed under the protection of the god Thoth. In the Book of the Dead, Chapter 82, the deceased states: “*I have come forth, my tongue is (that of) Ptah, my throat is (that of) Hathor*”². Furthermore, medical texts contain prescriptions for treating diseases of the tongue. Most of them were to be chewed and moved around the mouth with the tongue but then spat out again³. In the Ancient Egyptian language, various words were used to refer to the tongue and occasionally to its shape, such as:

1.  jm.j(t)-r³: Tongue (literally: what in the mouth is/exists)⁴.
2.  ns: Tongue is the most frequently used term to refer to the tongue in both humans and animals⁵.

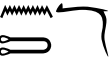
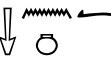
¹ Otto 1975, 20; Assmann 1983, 220-222, 238-240; Junker 1939.

² Hornung 1998; <https://www.aegyptologie.com/forum/cgi-bin/YaBB/YaBB.pl?action=lexikond&id=050618181026> (accessed 01.10.2025).

³ Westendorf 1992;

<https://www.aegyptologie.com/forum/cgi-bin/YaBB/YaBB.pl?action=lexikond&id=050618181026> (accessed 01.10.2025).

⁴ Wb 1, 74 (11); CT VI, 3760; <https://thesaurus-linguae-aegyptiae.de/lemma/25540>, in: *Thesaurus Linguae Aegyptiae* (accessed: 08.18.2025).

3.  nt: Tongue, is documented in the Pyramid texts and used frequently in the expression    “Hr.w hr nt .f: *If he is satisfied with (Horus because of his tongue (i.e. speech)), he is satisfied with this Pepi*”⁶.
4.  s.t-ns: Tongue⁷.
5.  sn.w: Tongue. This word is documented during the Greco-Roman Period⁸.
6.  snk: Tongue. This expression is evidenced since the 18th Dynasty and associated with the sacred cow Hathor, who licks the king with her tongue⁹.
It can also be compared with the term  snqi, which means “the breast of the mother or the wetnurse” as well as the verb “suckle”¹⁰. Moreover, it is also related to the mother goddess Hathor¹¹.
7.  šsʹ.w: Tongue¹². This term is relatively rare and used in early textual sources, such as the Pyramid Texts. In addition, it is a component in some private titles, such as “  šsʹ.w-nswt¹³;  šsʹ.w-n-bj.tj¹⁴;    šsʹ.w-bj.tj-n-Tʹ-Šmʹ.w¹⁵: *Royal Tongue (of*

⁵ Wb II, 320 (8-17); Weeks 1980, 104; Grapow 1954, 41; Deines/ Westendorf 1961, 479; Lefèvre 1952, 20.

⁶ Wb II, 357 (9); Sethe 1969, II, Pyr 1088b; Berger-el Naggar/Leclant/Mathieu/Pierre-Croisiau 2001, fig. 33-4, pl. XVIII; Allen 2005, 458.

⁷ Wb II, 320 (16)

⁸ Wb VI, 155 (15); <https://thesaurus-linguae-aegyptiae.de/lemma/136360> , in: *Thesaurus Linguae Aegyptiae* (accessed: 08.18.2025).

⁹ Wb IV, 177 (1); FCD, 234

¹⁰ Wb VI, 174 (5)-175 (1)

¹¹ Wb VI, 175 (2)

¹² Wb IV, 545 (1); Walker 1996, 276; Grapow 1954, 41; Lefèvre 1952, 20.

¹³ Jansen-Winkel 2007, 321.12.

¹⁴ Jansen-Winkel 2007, 217.6-218; <https://thesaurus-linguae-aegyptiae.de/lemma/884-036>, in: *Thesaurus Linguae Aegyptiae* (accessed: 8/19/2025)

¹⁵ Jansen-Winkel 2007, 95.21; <https://thesaurus-linguae-aegyptiae.de/lemma/8840-39>, in: *Thesaurus Linguae Aegyptiae* (accessed: 8/19/2025)

its anatomy²⁸. Furthermore, as is evident in the present day, the tongue in Egyptian texts occasionally bore semantic and metaphoric meanings²⁹.

In the Ancient Egyptians sign lists, there are very few signs that represent living beings with a protruding tongue, such as (G47) , which illustrates a quacking duckling,  (G48) demonstrating three quacking ducklings in a nest, or  (H18)³⁰.

Furthermore, the protruding tongue is closely associated with the act of licking, which was used in various contexts as well. For this word, the Ancient Egyptians used the expression  nsbi: to lick; to devour: ablecken; verschlingen³¹. This gesture has both positive and negative meaning, as this contribution demonstrates.

IV. The protruding tongue in Ancient Egyptian animal scenes

The protruding tongue in representations of animals in Ancient Egyptian art, whether in tomb and temple scenes or in three-dimensional pieces, was a common motif over time. It can be found in several contexts, which varied throughout history. These scenes were undoubtedly the product of the ancient Egyptian's observation of animal in the environment around and his impression of their behavior as he often observed it. This behavior occasionally acquired a religious or symbolic character or a metaphorical meaning with specific creatures in particular contexts. This relation of man and environment was influenced by social circumstances, such as philosophical notions, economic status, and religious beliefs, which were key factors in shaping the vision of people toward their environment, on physical and emotional levels³². The most significant and frequent instances of animal depicted with protruding tongue are as follows:

III.1. In cattle scenes

In ancient Egypt, cattle were of significant economic importance, as they served not only as providers for meat and milk, but also as symbols of worship and divinity. The keeping of cattle herds correlated with the economic stability and wealth of people. Furthermore, cattle were regularly counted in order to levy taxes³³. In addition, many

²⁸ Grapow 1954, 41; von Deines / Westendorf 1961, 479-481; von Deines /Grapow/Westendorf 1958, 67-68; Lefèvre 1952, 20, fn. 2.

²⁹ Regarding the linguistic and semantic significance of the tongue, see: Beck 2024, 163–177.

³⁰ Gardiner 1957, 273.

³¹ Wb II, 334 (11-14).

³² Evans 2020.

³³ Störk 1984, 257-263; Katary 2011,

(<http://digital2.library.ucla.edu/viewItem.do?ark=21198/zz002814vq>) (accessed 01.10.2025).

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goddesses, such as Hathor, Mehet-weret and Nut in particular, reflect this divine role. Cows were considered a symbol of fertility and motherhood, which explains their revered status.

III.1.1. Living cattle in daily life scenes

In ancient Egypt, the relationship between a cow and her calf symbolized the intimate bond of motherhood. This maternal association was often expressed artistically through gestures, most notably the depiction of the cow extending her tongue toward her calf. Although scenes and wooden models depicting the herding and counting of cattle are found in the tombs of individuals from the Old Kingdom to the Late Period³⁴, the depictions of a protruding tongue are striking and most prominent and frequent on the tomb walls of the Old Kingdom. It is essentially represented in scenes depicting pain, loud lowing or even the normal animal behavior in daily life activities. These include *the herding scenes*, which generally depict the cattle standing close together, forming a repeated, regular pattern, in which the complex overlapping of the depicted animals and persons is clearly intended. The main figures are the herdsman, occasionally with his stick on his shoulder, and another man carrying the calf on his back in the middle, who leads the herd across the water. The man with the calf uses the mothering instinct of the cattle, as the mother follows her calf and the herd follows her. In some cases, the herdsmen are depicted in a boat, while one of them holds the calf at the back of the boat to lure the mother cow and the rest of the herd behind it to cross the water. Instances could be found in the tombs of Niankhnesut (fig. 1)³⁵, Ankhmahor (fig. 2)³⁶, Mereruka (fig. 3)³⁷, Kagemni (fig. 4) and Princess Idut (fig. 5)³⁸. This instinct is strongly evident in the mother cow's longing for her calf, which then turns its head toward her. The artist depicts both with their tongues sticking out, symbolizing their loud mooing and expressing the desire to be together. Occasionally the artist even exaggerates this affection by having their tongues touch in unique examples, such as the one in the tomb of Princess Idut.

Scenes depicting *the delivery of the calf* in ancient Egyptian art reveal the Egyptians' careful observation of animal life in his environment. Such scenes have been identified with more or less common features and details in multiple tombs: the cow is often shown standing in a tense posture as the calf emerges, while three herdsmen assist the cow, one crouches on the ground behind the mother so that he can pull the front legs of

³⁴ E.g. Shehab 2022, 84-107; Saber 2022, 22-31; Arnold 1991, 5-48, Winlock 1955; Roehrig 2023, 159-172.

³⁵ Arnold 1999, no. 193, 468-469.

³⁶ Kanawati 1997, pl. 37.

³⁷ Duell 1938, pl. 21.

³⁸ <https://www.flickr.com/photos/manna4u/27427255562/in/photostream/> (accessed on 01.10.2025).

the calf, another man stands behind him and gives instructions for the right delivery, while the third man stands before the cow. The artist was keen to demonstrate a high level of observation by depicting the cow's profound suffering through the protruding tongue, which is used as a powerful visual instrument to convey the physical pain and effort of labor. This detail did not reflect merely the anatomical realism of the delivery process but a symbolic indication of the loud lowing of the animal and the suffering during the life-giving of the calf. Instances for this content with this form of tongue are attested in the tombs of Tjetu (fig. 6)³⁹, Iasen (fig. 7)⁴⁰, Senebi (fig. 8)⁴¹, Ti (fig. 9)⁴² and Niankhkhnum and Khnumhotep (fig. 10)⁴³.

Moreover, the protruding tongue is also evident in the scenes of *milking the cow* and of the cow suckling her calf, which reflects the dimension of maternal affection and emphasizes the intimate bond between mother and offspring. In milking scenes, the rare legs of the cow are usually tied, while a herdsman sits beside it and starts milking. The calf is occasionally tied to her front leg or is held by another herdsman or runs freely around his mother. The cow follows him with her head backward or bends toward the calf, sometimes with her tongue protruding to represent the loud lowing or to lick it. Same detail is represented in the *milking scenes*, in which the calf suckles from cow's udder. This gesture of licking, carefully imitated by Ancient Egyptian artists, expresses affection and physical relationship between cow and calf. This context is illustrated, for instance in the tombs of Ti (fig. 11)⁴⁴, Akh-merwt-niswt (fig. 12)⁴⁵, Kagemni (fig. 13), Ptahhotep (fig. 14)⁴⁶, Akhethotep (B-2) (fig. 15)⁴⁷, Baqet III (fig. 16)⁴⁸, and on the sarcophagus of Queen Aashyt (fig. 17).

Furthermore, cows are represented protruding their tongues in scenes to reflect their natural behavior while eating the grass or drinking water, such as the illustrations in the tombs of Nebemakhet (fig. 18)⁴⁹, Ti (fig. 19) and Niankhkhnum and Khnumhotep (fig. 20)⁵⁰. Moreover, the artist frequently illustrated young calves accompanying the

³⁹ Simpson 1980, fig. 22.

⁴⁰ Simpson 1980, fig. 30.

⁴¹ Blackman 1914a, pl. X.

⁴² Wild 1966, pl. CXXIV.

⁴³ <https://www.flickr.com/photos/manna4u/5241284757/in/photostream/> (accessed on 01.10.2025); Moussa 1977, Pls. 77, 79. See also: Roth 1995, fig.204; Shehab 2022, 7(1), 87.

⁴⁴ Wild 1966, pl. CXXIV.

⁴⁵ Smith 1949, 208, fig. 79.

⁴⁶ Davies 1901, pl. XVII.

⁴⁷ Blackman 1914b, pl. VII.

⁴⁸ Davies 1933, fig. 10.

⁴⁹ LD II, pl. 12; PM III-1, 230.

⁵⁰ <https://www.flickr.com/photos/manna4u/5241867530/in/photostream/> (accessed on 01.10.2025).

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procession of the offering bearers in a very lively manner, with the calves happily jumping, turning their heads back, playing with each other, and occasionally sticking out their small tongues as representation of making joyful sounds (fig. 21)⁵¹.

III.1.2. Slaughtered cattle or heads in the offering scenes and hunting cattle

Episodes of cattle slaughter are documented in ancient Egyptian tombs to depict not only a frequent daily life activity, but also effective ritual practices that ensure the eternal offerings for the deceased in the afterlife. These scenes often show the process of slaughter, starting with controlling the animal and restraining the animal tightly, slaughtering its throat, and then dismembering the body into pieces (fig 22)⁵². Moreover, there are many reliefs demonstrating the well-fed sacrifice animals in festival processions or on their way to the slaughterhouse of the temple (figs 23) ⁵³. The protruding tongue is present in the following cases: in the processions where cows move slowly and breathe with difficulty under the weight of their heavy bodies (figs 23, 24), during controlling the animal as a sign of loud lowing and its panic (fig. 25⁵⁴, 26⁵⁵), after slaughtering, when the tied animals are lying on the ground, and finally in scenes representing the slaughtered cattle or their cut-off heads offered to the deities by the pharaoh (figs 27, 28)⁵⁶ or carried by offering bearers or priests (figs 29, 30)⁵⁷. In this context, this form of the tongue serves as a definitive sign of the animal's fright and then its death. The same symbolism applies also to the few scenes of hunting cattle. An excellent instance for this latter is a relief from the temple of Medinet Habu, in which Ramses III hunts strong bulls and successfully hits them with his arrows. The panic, pain and loud lowing of the animal is expressed by the protruding tongue as well (fig. 31)⁵⁸.

III.2. (Male) Cats with protruding tongue

III.2.1. In daily life scenes

⁵¹ Kanawati 1997, pls. 47-51.

⁵² Kanawati 1997, pl. 49.

⁵³ [https://www.flickr.com/photos/manna4u/22984052603/;https://www.flickr.com/photos/manna4u/23315357940/in/photostream/](https://www.flickr.com/photos/manna4u/22984052603/) (accessed 01.10.2025); Medinet Habu III, OIP 23, pl. 173.

⁵⁴ Martin 1979, pl. 13; Blackman 1914a, pl. XI.

⁵⁵ Blackman 1914a, pl. XI.

⁵⁶ Medinet Habu III, OIP 23, pl. 179; Kanawati 1997, pls. 62-64.

⁵⁷ Medinet Habu III, OIP 23, pl. 173; Davies 1941, pl. XIII.

⁵⁸ Medinet Habu II, pl. 117.

Cats were desirable animals in Ancient Egypt. Remains of them were found in Hierakonpolis in Upper Egypt in one of the Predynastic burials (HK6)59. Moreover, they were domesticated and used in private (nick)names, and depicted in daily life private scenes, such as hunting desert animals, marsh scenes or under the chairs of the elite60. Generally, they are represented with sealed mouths61, however, in few cases, they stick out their tongues as a sign of meowing. Excellent examples for this latter are found in the tomb of May (TT 130) from the 18. Dynasty, in which a cat is tied to the leg of a chair and looks forward to a bowl full of meat but cannot reach it (fig. 32)62, and in the tomb of Nebamun and Ipuky (TT 181), which illustrates the cat under a chair of noble ladies during a banquet (fig. 33)63. Moreover, anthropomorphized animals that act like humans were depicted on ostraca and papyri and served as a medium of humor, social criticism, and entertainment. They present a simple visual narrative style of popular art that mixes satire with ethical or amusing fables without accompanying texts64. Among the animals represented acting as humans are cats65 which occasionally stick out their tongues. Here the tongue as indication of the human voice that the anthropomorphized animals simulate (figs. 34-36)66. Although human figures in Ancient Egyptian art aren't shown with protruding tongue to refer to their normal voice during talking, the artist employed this feature to convey the concept of anthropomorphizing animals to the viewer, indicating that they could speak like humans.

On the divine level, cats were worshipped in Ancient Egypt as a symbol of the goddess Bastet and were mummified in great numbers. Furthermore, numerous amulets and bronze figures depicting cats have been discovered from various periods, particularly the Late Period and later on67.

III.2.2. In religious context

⁵⁹ Linseele, V. et al 2007, 2081, 2086 ; van Neer et al. 2014, 103-110.

⁶⁰ Malek 2006, 47-72; El-Kilany/Mahran 2015, 250.

⁶¹ Malek 2006; El-Kilany/Mahran 2015, 250-252; Wilkinson/Hill 1983, 33-35.

⁶² Malek 2006, 63; Wilkinson/Hill 1983, 84-85;
<https://www.metmuseum.org/art/collection/search/557635> (accessed 01.10.2025).

⁶³ Davies 1936, pl. LXI; Malek 2006, 61.

⁶⁴ For detailed study of the anthropomorphized animals, see: Babcock 2014.

⁶⁵ Malek 2006, 112-122.

⁶⁶ Babcock 2022, pls 112, 148, 138.

⁶⁷ Malek 2006, 73-111.

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Remarkably, male cats⁶⁸ are strongly present in Chapter 17 of the Book of the Dead, where they represent the Great Cat of Heliopolis slaying the foe of the sun god, the serpent Apophis, with a knife in front of the Ished-tree. This chapter, related to CT 335 from the Middle Kingdom, aims essentially to overcome the great danger that threatens the sun god during his journey and to guarantee his successful rise in the morning⁶⁹. The represented cats are not the domesticated type, rather the wild one⁷⁰. Most vignettes demonstrate the Great Cat with sealed mouth⁷¹, except for few examples, such as those on the walls of the tomb of Inherkhau (TT 359) (fig. 37)⁷², or on P. Dublin MS 1661 (fig. 38)⁷³. Particularly the Great Cat in Inherkhaus is striking as it has faint spots on its fur and unusual long straight ears that resemble those of a hare. Malek doesn't recognize a specific kind of cat in this figure and wonders whether it represents any real species. He suggests that the artist created this imaginary feline form (cat-like), possibly for symbolic or artistic purposes⁷⁴. The protruding tongue here is associated with this unusual and infrequent cat form and may symbolize the apotropaic, loud meow of the sun god to frighten the serpent so that it would not attack him while he cuts his head off.

Similar to Lions, cat-shaped deities were generally depicted with sealed mouth, however, rare representations demonstrate them with a protruding tongue. A remarkable instance is found on an ostrakon in the Egyptian Museum and Papyrus Collection in Berlin (Inv. ÄM 21443) and illustrates the goddess Tefnut as a cat in the context of the Myth of the Eye of the Sun god Re (fig. 39)⁷⁵. The myth describes the anger of Re's daughter and eye, Tefnut, and her leaving to the deserts of Nubia in the form of a cat, and how Re wished her return, and therefore sent the god of wisdom, Thoth, to bring her back. Thoth, in a monkey form, went to the angry goddess and started calming her by telling amusing animal fables. Eventually, he succeeded in

⁶⁸ In rare scenes, the cat slaying Apophis is actually a female cat, probably because it is identified with a female deceased or to a daughter of Re (Hathor?). Vgl. Pinch 1993, 191-192; Malek 2006, 87.

⁶⁹ Malek 2006, 84-89; Quirke 2013, 76.

⁷⁰ Malek 2006, 84.

⁷¹ E.g. Pap. Hunefer (EA9901) from the 19. Dynasty

(https://www.britishmuseum.org/collection/object/Y_EA9901-1?selectedImageId=818143001), Pap. of the Princess Nesitanebtashru from the 21. Dyn (BM EA10554)

(https://www.britishmuseum.org/collection/object/Y_EA10554-76); Shorter 1938, pl. X; Malek 2006, 85.

⁷² Malek 2006, 87; Bruyère 1933, 66-67, pl. XX-XXI.

⁷³ Naville 1886, pl. XXX; <https://totenbuch.awk.nrw.de/objekt/tm134343#> (accessed 01.10.2025).

⁷⁴ Malek 2006, 87.

⁷⁵ Babcock 2023, 23; Babcock 2022, 168; Quack 2010, 345.

calming down and convincing her to return to her father. The scene on this ostrakon has been described as a display of this myth. Interestingly, the cat is depicted with its tongue protruding and violently shaking a stick at Thoth, the monkey⁷⁶. The tongue here is an obvious sign of its loud meow reflecting ferocity and outrage, in contrast to the calm monkey, who tries to contain her anger.

III.3. Lions/lioness with protruding tongue

Lions have been known in Egypt since the Predynastic Period and were illustrated up to the Late Period, particularly in desert representations. Although hunting lions is shown only on palettes of the early period and then again in the Middle Kingdom as a royal privilege, capturing lions is also depicted in the Old Kingdom. Moreover, the characteristics of lions shaped both the daily life as well as the divine concept of this animal in the Ancient Egyptian perception. Among these characteristics are the strength and wildness, the terrifying roar, and its striking external appearance with the mane⁷⁷. Due to their fierce nature, they were employed in Ancient Egyptian texts and iconography as a zoological symbol of the ruler, representing his strength and authority and simultaneously reflecting his divine nature and associations with the deities⁷⁸.

III.3.1. In daily life scenes

Exactly like cats, lions are most likely represented with sealed mouths, however, in few instances they stick out their tongues. Remarkable instances of this form are found on the lid of one of the Tutankhamun's Box from his well-known tomb (fig. 40)⁷⁹, as well as on the walls of the temple of Medinet Habu of Ramses III (fig. 41)⁸⁰, which represent the king on his chariot hunting lions in the desert. This royal sport displays the king's power and capability to overcome even the most powerful creatures in the environment, and consequently the chaos. Lions in these scenes are hit by the king's arrows and are represented either dead or bellowing due to the severe pain. A protruding tongue serves as a visual language to refer to the intense panting following the long chase, the loud bellows of pain or the relaxation of the body, jaw muscles, and tongue as a result of death.

In addition to hunting, lions were tamed, trained and domesticated in royal palaces as well. Therefore, they are frequently represented accompanying kings, especially in the

⁷⁶ Flores 2004, 250-251; 113-114, pl. 46; Babcock 2023, 21, 23; Quack 2010, 345.

⁷⁷ Rössler-Köhler 1980, 1080.

⁷⁸ Rössler-Köhler 1980, 1081-1082, 1086; Moustafa/Abdel Razek/Bayoumy 2024, 17-36.

⁷⁹ <https://www.globalegyptianmuseum.org/record.aspx?id=15097> (accessed 01.10.2025); Davis 1936, pl. LXXVII.

⁸⁰ Medinet Habu I, OIP 8, pl. 35.

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New Kingdom, in various contexts, e.g. hunting and military scenes. In the Late Period, lions were represented with ornaments, such as neckbands, which may clarify that the purpose of capturing lions was training and domesticating⁸¹. In such representations, lions stick out their tongues occasionally, while walking (fig. 42)⁸² or running (figs 43, 44)⁸³ next to the chariot of the king. In a military context, the protruding tongue may signify the terrifying roar of the royal lions, an expression meant to strike fear into the hearts of the king's enemies. It also conveys the animals' readiness to engage actively in battle, attacking the king's foes and tearing them apart, as they were probably trained to do. On the other hand, in hunting scenes, the tongue could be an indication of the tame and domestication of the lions and that they do not represent any danger to the king and his entourage, unlike the wild lion which the king hunts in the desert. This concept is closely related to a very astonishing cosmetic jar of Tutankhamun (JE 62119), which is flanked by lotus columns, each is topped with the head of the god Bes and rests on the head of an Asiatic and a Nubian enemy (fig 45)⁸⁴. Interestingly, the lid of the jar is surmounted by a recumbent lion with crossed paws that bears the cartouche of Tutankhamun⁸⁵. The pose of the lion is already attested under his previous ancestor, Amenophis III⁸⁶. The protruding tongue in this piece is present in the following points: 1. In the hunting scene, in which the hunted bull bellows of pain as the lion attacks his neck. 2. In the heads of Bes, which are usually featured by the protruding tongue for apotropaic and protective purposes, as will be discussed later. 3. The most prominent visual element is the tongue of the lion on the lid, a very rare feature in three-dimensional lions. The tongues in Bes figures as well as in the lion are made of ivory stained red⁸⁷ to imitate the actual organ. In the case of the lion on the lid, it may refer to the domestication of the wild animal, as previously assumed. However, it has been suggested that this lion represents the king himself, or even as a form of Bes⁸⁸.

A further similar lion from the tomb of Tutankhamun is represented in a lion-shaped vessel but with few differences (fig. 46)⁸⁹: The vessel is shaped as a standing lion on its rare legs upon a pedestal, while its right leg steps forward. Its right arm is raised

⁸¹ Rössler-Köhler 1980, 1080; Moustafa et al. 2024, 74.

⁸² Bailleul-LeSuer 2016, 620.

⁸³ Medinet Habu I, OIP 8, pl. 17; Medinet Habu II, OIP 9, pl. 77.

⁸⁴ <https://www.globalegyptianmuseum.org/record.aspx?id=15079> (accessed 01.10.2025); Manniche 2019, 25-26, pls. XXXIII- XXXIII.

⁸⁵ Manniche 2019, 25-26.

⁸⁶ Manniche 2019, 25-26; Edwards 1976, 124; Graves-Brown 2018, 48.

⁸⁷ Manniche 2019, 25-26.

⁸⁸ Edwards 1976, 124.

⁸⁹ Manniche 2019, 25-26, pls. XXVIII- XXXI.

with a flat opened hand and the left arm rests on the sign of protection (s3). Similar to the previous instance, the mouth of the lion is wide open and has a long protruding tongue made of ivory and stained red to imitate the actual tongue. However, the lion here possesses back and front sharp teeth, also of ivory. Cartouches of Tutankhamun and his spouse are inscribed on the chest of the animal⁹⁰. Unlike the lion in the previous jar, the gilded eyes and the tongue protruding from between the teeth strongly reminds of a real lion in a moment of anger or attack, poised to pounce on its prey. This delivers a completely different impression than the one of the toothless, recumbent lion. The sharp teeth, the protruding tongue, the hand on the symbol of protection (s3) and the feather crown on the head leave no doubt that this lion represents the protection god Bes, who was occasionally associated with lions in Ancient Egypt. Very similar figures of Bes in the lion form, but in profile view flank Bes in the dwarf form in the bed of King Tutankhamun as well, aiming to protect the king from all evil (fig. 47)⁹¹. These undoubtedly emphasize the identity of the lion as a form of the protective Bes.

Furthermore, the well-known erotic papyrus no. 55001 in Turin⁹² presents a unique scene of animals sticking out their tongues, including a lion. This papyrus has been interpreted as a representation of the royal festival "spending the beautiful day" and contains two main sections: an animal section and an erotic one⁹³. In the animal section, four animals are anthropomorphized and represented as musicians imitating human behavior. They stand on the two rare legs, and each plays a different musical instrument (fig. 48)⁹⁴. The second animal in the scene depicts a lion playing a large, asymmetrical lyre, while its shoulder and forearm pass through the lyre's frame, creating an unusual link between musician and instrument. Most striking here is the red tongue protruding from the lion's open mouth⁹⁵ that clearly expresses the human voice during singing and emphasizes the humanization of the animal.

III.3.2. In religious context

Lion-shaped deities are attested from the earliest times on, most well-known are Sakhmet of Memphis, Bastet of Bubastis, Pakhet, Hathor and Menhit. Their nature combining motherhood, protection and violent qualities was attractive to the Egyptians to be embodied and worshipped. Moreover, Shu and Tefnut, the children of the Atum of Heliopolis and the first generation of the Heliopolitan Ennead, are depicted as the

⁹⁰ Manniche 2019, 25-26.

⁹¹ https://ancienegypte.fr/2musee_caire2018/page8.htm (accessed 01.10.2025).

⁹² Omlin 1973.

⁹³ Kessler 1988, 171-196.

⁹⁴ Omlin 1973, 28, pl. XIV; Babcock 2014, 77-78, pl. 4.

⁹⁵ Omlin 1973, 28, pl. XIV.

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double lions "Ruti" represented back-to-back⁹⁶. Despite the wild nature of lions, these deities are usually depicted with sealed mouths. However, in rare cases lion-headed demons and underworld guards are represented with their tongue stuck out. For instance, the papyrus of Nespaheeran (PSkrine No. 2) from the Third Intermediate Period at the Bodleian Library in Oxford contains parts of the Book of the Dead, consists of 32 recitations for several deities in various forms. One of these is a lion-headed man with a feline tail, standing on a pedestal bearing the title: Ruler of the Living. According to the accompanying text, the name of the deity is  : Ntt.f m nkt, who will not have power over the limb of the deceased and will not eat his flesh or devour his bones (fig. 49)⁹⁷. On the same papyrus, there is another lion-headed deity called Amun, who fights the rkk-snake for the deceased and will not permit that his body to be held in the Necropolis. He, however, illustrated in a mummified form and has a long snake in his mouth (fig. 50)⁹⁸. Both possess protruding tongues which may refer to the loud roar symbolizing protection through frightening away the evil and dangerous creatures, such as snakes, and consequently protecting the deceased from harm and damage in the afterlife.

III.4. Donkeys with protruding tongue

The following case study focuses on the protruding tongue in donkey scenes. Although donkeys played a crucial role in Ancient Egyptian daily and religious life, they have been rarely depicted with their tongues stuck out, rather mostly with closed mouths, despite the impression of movement in their body or even pain⁹⁹. It is depicted essentially in the following three contexts: 1. In the daily life scenes, representing field activities (fig. 51)¹⁰⁰. Here, a donkey is represented protruding tongue while drinking water, what reflects their natural behavior. 2. In hunting scenes, in which donkeys are represented among the desert animals chased by the pharaoh. The scene from the temple of Medinet Habu illustrated the donkeys in the lower part hit by Ramses III's arrows (fig. 52)¹⁰¹. The tongue indicates that the animals either are dead or bellowing due to severe pain. Thus, the tongue serves as a visual language to refer to the intense

⁹⁶ Rössler-Köhler 1980, 1081-1082; Sabbahy 2020, 54-55, 63.

⁹⁷ Blackman 1918, 28, pl. III.

⁹⁸ Blackman 1918, 32, pl. V.

⁹⁹ E.g. Davies 1901, pl. VIII; Simpson 1980, fig. 4, 40; Murray 1905, pl. XI; Davies 1913, pl. XII; Lashien 2020, 121-137; Wild 1966, pl. CLII-CLV; Wreszinski/ Schäfer/ Grapow 1936, pl. 46-52; Kanawati 1997, pl. 37; Mastaba of Ti <https://www.flickr.com/photos/manna4u/5249307752/in/photostream/> (accessed 01.10.2025); Diab 2017, 179-196; Vandenbeusch 2020.

¹⁰⁰ Martin 1979, pl. 10; Harpur 1987 fig. 42.

¹⁰¹ Medinet Habu II, OIP 9, pl. 116.

panting following the long chase, the loud bellows of pain or the relaxation of the body, jaw muscles, and tongue as a result of death. This may also symbolize defeating evil and chaos as donkeys were symbol of the god Seth. 3. In addition, in the previously mentioned papyrus no. 55001 in Turin¹⁰², an anthropomorphized donkey is depicted leading the four musicians (fig. 48)¹⁰³. Like the animals in the group, it stands on the two rare legs, and plays a harp bent to the right¹⁰⁴. Similar to the lion after it, the anthropomorphized donkey imitates human behavior, and the protruding tongue signifies the human voice during singing and emphasizes the humanization of the animal. It's humorous that the donkey is leading the musicians as a singer, given its reputation for its annoying, unmelodious braying. This may reflect a form of social criticism, as seen in many satirical depictions of anthropomorphic animals, suggesting the misallocation of responsibilities and tasks to unqualified people.

III.5. Hippopotamus with protruding tongue

In Ancient Egypt, the hippopotamus was a local animal closely associated with the river and the marshlands. They usually come to the riverbank at night to feed, often destroying crops and endangering people. Consequently, hippos are often regarded as hostile and aggressive animals that were frequently hunted. Moreover, their ivory was considered a valuable material that was used in many objects in Ancient Egypt. Furthermore, Hippo has a complex religious significance, symbolizing not only harmful chaos but also positive powers of protection, fertility, and rebirth¹⁰⁵.

III.5.1. In daily life scenes

Hippo hunting has been documented since the First Dynasty. They were hunted with bows and loops, as well as with spears, both in groups and individually¹⁰⁶. The Egyptian kings are frequently depicted hunting hippopotami, symbolizing Seth, the enemy of Horus. Through this ritual, which became a tradition until the Greco-Roman Period, the ruler maintains the Maat, i.e., the cosmic order, against chaos¹⁰⁷. There is no doubt that the hunting process was extremely painful for the animal, as the hippos were frequently represented bellowing, opening their mouths wide, and sticking out their tongues in expressions of the intensity of the pain. Excellent instances are depicted in the tombs of Ti (fig. 53)¹⁰⁸ and Idut (fig. 54)¹⁰⁹. Similar cause is also

¹⁰² Omlin 1973.

¹⁰³ Omlin 1973, 28, pl. XIV.

¹⁰⁴ Omlin 1973, 28; Babcock 2014, 5, 77-78, pl. 4.

¹⁰⁵ Störk 1982, 501-506.

¹⁰⁶ Störk 1982, 501-506.

¹⁰⁷ Störk 1982, 502; Müller 2008, 285-289.

¹⁰⁸ <https://www.flickr.com/photos/manna4u/44522545732/> (accessed 01.10.2025).

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represented in the birth scenes, in which the mother sticks tongue out due to severe pain (fig. 55)¹¹⁰.

III.5.2. In religious context

On the divine level hippopotamus was not only associated with negative connotations as an emblem of Seth. Several goddesses, such as Ipet and Taweret “The Great One” are regarded as helper in childbirth, protection and fertility also contribute to the hippopotamus's positive side. Taweret is documented from the Old Kingdom on and represented with the body of a female hippopotamus with the tail of a crocodile on her back, lion feet, and drooping female breasts. This form was intended to drive away evil spirits and protect women and babies during childbirth. Therefore, Taweret enjoyed prominent position in Ancient Egypt, particularly in popular religion and was represented on beds, headrests, amulets, magic wands etc¹¹¹. Taweret is represented with sealed mouth, open mouth, open mouth with protruding tongue, occasionally together with a snake. She usually rests her hand on the protection sign s3 or a knife (fig. 56)¹¹². Ipet had a similar form and was also associated with protection and rebirth. For instance, in Chapter 137 of the Book of the Dead on the papyrus of Ani from the 19. Dynasty, she burns incense and holds a torch to provide light for the dead (fig. 57)¹¹³. Interestingly, these hippo-goddesses are frequently depicted with protruding tongues which reflect their protective and apotropaic aspect¹¹⁴ and simultaneously represent their loud bellow.

Eventually, it is worth mentioning that in some instances, there was somehow (con)fusion between Taweret und the devourer Ammit. The latter is represented as hybrid creature that typically consists of crocodile's head, lion's forepart, and a hippopotamus's back part, reversed to the elements that compose the also hybrid form of Taweret¹¹⁵. One of the three ritual beds of Tutankhamun discovered by Carter in his tomb is represented as two figures of Taweret/Ammit with hippopotamus's head and a protruding tongue (fig. 58)¹¹⁶. The main purpose of this form is protection and driving away the evil.

¹⁰⁹ <https://www.flickr.com/photos/manna4u/26917648383/in/photostream/> (accessed 01.10.2025).

¹¹⁰ <https://www.flickr.com/photos/manna4u/27427089152/> (accessed 01.10.2025).

¹¹¹ Wilkinson 2007, 184-186; Graves-Brown 2018, 42-46.

¹¹² Wilkinson 2007, 185.

¹¹³ Wilkinson 2007, 185.

¹¹⁴ Wilkinson 2007, 185.

¹¹⁵ Schutz 2021, 141-142.

¹¹⁶ <https://www.flickr.com/photos/manna4u/26954783462/in/photostream/> (accessed 01.10.2025).

IV. The protruding tongue in Ancient Egyptian human contexts

A paucity of evidence exists to substantiate the depictions of the human tongue protruding in Ancient Egyptian art, even in cases of the most violent and painful acts. This is evidenced in the fighting scenes, such as those of boatmen in the tombs of the Old and Middle Kingdom¹¹⁷, or wrestling scenes, such as those at Beni Hassan¹¹⁸ or Medinet Habu¹¹⁹, or the scenes of battlefield¹²⁰, or even the circumcision¹²¹ or punishment scenes¹²², such as those of non-payment of taxes in the mastabas of the Old Kingdom. This applies to scenes of feasts, banquets, singing and dancing¹²³, as well as scenes of mourning, grief, and funerals, in which the individuals may make loud sounds or screams. There are also scenes of animal herding and birth, in which the foreman issues instructions and gestures to his subordinates, or erotic representations, such as those on the well-known Turin Papyrus. In contrast to the animal scenes, the protruding tongue is depicted in a much smaller scale in human figures. However, evidence for this gesture is mostly documented in textual sources. Moreover, this evidence, both textually and iconographically, is essentially related to (defeated) enemies.

IV.1. The protruding tongue in Ancient Egyptian human iconography

Despite their few numbers, the scenes of individuals present striking details. These are evidenced in the following contexts:

IV.1.1. In the battle scenes or the representations of the foreigners

In numerous representations of the ancient Egyptian king or queens as sphinxes—or, in rare scenes, as griffins—trampling upon the traditional Nubian, Libyan and Asian foes, which are documented since the Old Kingdom and symbolize control over the foreign lands, the enemies are usually depicted in a passive posture, usually kneeling in complete submission, without any attempting to defend themselves, or raising their

¹¹⁷ Harpur 1987, fig. 82, 181, 113-117; Bolshakov 1993, 29-39; Sist 2022, 213-226; Azzam 2007, 11-27; Herb 2002; Keshka 2022, 151-172; Hassan 1949.

¹¹⁸ Motte 2017, 53-70; Förster 2005, 71-83; Decker 1976, 7-24; Schulman, A. R., *The Battle Scene of the Middle Kingdom*, JSSEA 12 (1982), 165-83.

¹¹⁹ Ebied 2015, 1-17, fig. 1, 10; Touny 1969, 22-23, fig. 6.

¹²⁰ Schoske 1982

¹²¹ Wreszinski/ Schäfer/ Grapow 1936, pl. 25-26.

¹²² Harpur 1987, figs. 160-162, 204, 210; Davies 1902, pl. 8; Duell OIP 31 (1938), pl. 37; Wreszinski/ Schäfer/ Grapow 1936, pl. 68.

¹²³ E.g. Harpur 1987, fig. 58M; Junker 1940, 57, fig. 13; LD II, pl. 61; Simpson 1980, fig. 6; Wreszinski/ Schäfer/ Grapow 1936, pl. 30-32.

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hands in defense gesture and humility before the king¹²⁴. In rare scenes, the defeated enemies have a protruding tongue. The earliest instance is found in the mortuary temple of Pepi II. in Saqqara, which depicts the king as a sphinx trampling an unidentified, fallen enemy, who sticks his tongue out (fig. 59)¹²⁵. Although the scene is fragmentary and strongly destroyed, the leg of the lion as well as its paw on the face of the foe, can still be identified.

The following instance is a decoration of the base, on which King Amenophis III is sitting on his throne, facing the unknown tomb owner. The decoration illustrates four Asian chiefs whose arms are tied to a papyrus stem, kneeling before the king so that their chins almost touch the ground (fig. 60)¹²⁶. Unusually, the mouths of these four individuals are open, so that their teeth are clearly shown, representing pain, humiliation, and defeat of the enemy¹²⁷. However, the second person seems to have his tongue protruding an additional emphasizing gesture of pain.

The previously mentioned box of Tutankhamun from his tomb presents extraordinary instances of enemies with their tongues sticking out as well¹²⁸. On one side, the king is illustrated on his chariot smiting the Nubians, who flee in panic before him, while his arrows hit their bodies. A detail from this scene represents an Egyptian soldier cutting the arm of one of the Nubians with a knife, while the latter loudly screams due to the severe pain, so that he protrudes his tongue (fig. 61). Similar detail is represented on the other side of the same box, however, with Asians; one falls under the royal chariot, probably dead (fig. 62)¹²⁹, the second is depicted facing the chariot and hit by the king's arrows (fig. 63)¹³⁰, and the last one is attacked by the royal dog, which sinks its teeth firmly into his body¹³¹.

The final iconographic evidence is found on a fragment of a model made by an artist, most probably during the Late Period (fig. 64)¹³². The relief illustrates the head of an Asian prince (?) whose nose has been cut as a physical punishment in Ancient

¹²⁴ For the motif in Ancient Egypt, see: Moustafa/Abdel Razek/Bayoumy 2024, 17-36; Schoske 1982, 359-417; Janzen 2013. <https://digitalcommons.memphis.edu/etd/661> (accessed 15.08.2025)

¹²⁵ Jéquier 1940, vol. III, pl. 18.

¹²⁶ Davis 1936, vol III, pl. LX, 115.

¹²⁷ Davis 1936, vol III, 115

¹²⁸ <https://www.globalegyptianmuseum.org/record.aspx?id=15097>

¹²⁹ Hawass/Vannini 2008.

¹³⁰ Hawass/Vannini 2008, 25.

¹³¹ Hawass/Vannini 2008, 25.

¹³² Keimer 1954, Tf. XIV.

Egypt¹³³. Furthermore, the figure is depicted protruding his tongue in an emphasizing gesture of humiliation and pain. This design serves as a model for the artists to apply during their work in scenes depicting foes under the feet of the pharaohs.

Finally, it is worth noting that various ancient Egyptian demons and deities, often depicted in human or hybrid form, are frequently represented with a protruding tongue. The most prominent is Bes,¹³⁴ whose name may mean “to protect”¹³⁵. He is closely associated with protection in general, and the protection of mothers, newborns and children during birth in particular¹³⁶. Therefore, its image is one of the most frequently represented images on beds and headrests¹³⁷ (fig. 66)¹³⁸, and occasionally on other equipment, such as the royal chariots to protect (the back of) the king from enemies (fig. 67)¹³⁹. Bes is depicted on numerous objects from the Middle Kingdom, however, his images and figurines become popular from the New Kingdom onwards. His form evolved and varied over time, ranging from a lion figure standing on its rear legs to a dwarf with long hair and short legs, as well as the lion's mane and tail¹⁴⁰. However, the most eye-catching facial feature is his protruding tongue, which has been exaggerated in some cases to emphasize its apotropaic effect or probably to his singing voice as he was regarded as a singer and a dancer¹⁴¹ (fig. 65)¹⁴². On the other hand, the tongue of Bes may refer to his link to his form as lion, or to the protruding tongues of babies¹⁴³.

Furthermore, there are indications of gods and demons, e.g. Sakhmet's messengers, who are said to shoot arrows from their mouths, as pLeiden I 346 states¹⁴⁴:

”Hail to you, these gods, slaughtering demons, associates of Sakhmet, who come forth from the eye of Re, messengers throughout the nomes, who make slaughter, who

¹³³ Cutting the nose was a common punishment for specific crimes in Ancient Egypt as well as for foreign foes as also a sign of humiliation and control. For this act, see: Muhlestein 2015; Müller-Wollermann 2015, 228–235; Megahed/Rafat 2024, 664–654.

¹³⁴ Wb I, 476 (8); LGG II, 834–835.

¹³⁵ Wilkinson 2007, 102.

¹³⁶ Wilkinson 2007, 102; van Oppen de Ruiter 2020, 1–27.

¹³⁷ Wilkinson 2007, 103; Graves-Brown 2018, 35–36.

¹³⁸ <https://www.globalegyptianmuseum.org/detail.aspx?id=15074> (accessed 01.10.2025).

¹³⁹ <https://www.flickr.com/photos/sandrovannini/4250080981/in/photostream/> (accessed 01.10.2025); Littauer/Crouwel 1985, 20, 111, pl. XIX.

¹⁴⁰ Wilkinson 2007, 102–103; Volokhine 2010, 233–255.

¹⁴¹ Volokhine 2010, 239; Graves-Brown 2018, 36.

¹⁴² Wilkinson 2007, 104.

¹⁴³ Graves-Brown 2018, 58 (5). Graves-Brown points out here also that there are Shabti figures represented with protruding tongues, however without mentioning further reference.

¹⁴⁴ Ritner/ Scalf 2019, 189 (30); Borghouts 1979, 12.

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create disturbance, who travel throughout the land, who shoot their arrows from their mouth(s).”

The text precisely describes the capability of specific creatures to convert their tongues into arrows to cause harm¹⁴⁵. This action reflects a negative, dangerous aspect of the protruding tongue and compares it with a dart¹⁴⁶. Furthermore, the danger lies not only in resemblance of the tongue to arrows, but also in regarding these latter as carriers of the plague spread by Sakhmet's messengers, as mentioned in the Book of the Last Day of the Year¹⁴⁷. Thus, the protruding tongue has an actual dangerous meaning as a cause of the plague's transmission, and not merely a metaphorical threat. In other context, sticking out the tongue has been identified with a knife¹⁴⁸:

"your tongue is directed towards her (i.e., probably to Hathor) as a pointed knife". Here, sticking out the tongue was compared with pointing out with knife toward a goddess, which emphasizes its threatening function.

IV.1.2. The protruding tongue in the scenes of feeding of animals

In very few evidence, the protruding tongue of human figures is present as well. The most prominent scene in this context is found in the tomb of Kagemni from the 6. Dynasty in Saqqara (fig. 68)¹⁴⁹, a statuette (JE 72143) from the 6. Dynasty Mastaba in Giza (G 7715 a) (fig. 69)¹⁵⁰, and Amulet (UC 38150), from the 6 Dynasty or the First Intermediate Period (fig. 70)¹⁵¹. In previous studies, the representation of Kagemni has been described as a piglet¹⁵², while in recent research as a newborn dog/a puppy drinking from the mouth of a herdsman, under another scene of a dog drinking from a bowl¹⁵³. Just as there is debate among researchers about the animal depicted, there are also discussions concerning the nature of the activity represented in this scene. It has been suggested that the depicted tongue between the mouth of the man and the muzzle of the dog belongs to the latter, and the herdsman spurts milk that

¹⁴⁵ Meeks 2008, 155 (no. 555).

¹⁴⁶ Meeks 2008, 155 (no. 555); Meeks 1995, 67, 269 (no. 71); Borghouts 1971, 90 (no. 151).

¹⁴⁷ Borghouts 1979, 12; Lang 2013, 108.

¹⁴⁸ Borghouts 1971, 90 (no. 151); CT III 250 (225).

¹⁴⁹ <https://www.flickr.com/photos/manna4u/page43> (accessed 01.10.2025); Thiringer 2020, 152, fig. 5.

¹⁵⁰ This small, painted limestone statue depicts a squatting man holding an animal, possibly a dog, goat, or calf. The man's skin is painted in reddish-brown, with black hair, while the animal is rendered in yellow-brown with black spots. Miles 2010, 73, fig. 2; Thiringer 2020, 26, 152, fig. 6; <http://giza.fas.harvard.edu/objects/22791/full/> (accessed 01.10.2025).

¹⁵¹ Miles 2010, 73, fig. 3; Thiringer 2020, 26, 152, fig. 7.

¹⁵² Helck 1984, 763; Ikram 1995, 30, 305; Firth/Gunn 1926, 114; Janssen/Janssen 1989, 33-34.

¹⁵³ Miles 2010, 71-72; Firth/Gunn 1926, Tf. 52; Harpur/Scremin 2006, 62, 377, 493.

he drank from the jar presented by the standing man before him, to the tongue of the dog¹⁵⁴. Others described the scene as feeding a dog or partially chewing the food for sick animal¹⁵⁵. However, some scholars question the validity of the first interpretation based on the manner dogs drink liquids, which does not correspond to the depiction illustrated in Kagemni's scene and to the wider context on the tomb wall. Probably, the seated herdsman had a mouthful of milk, held the puppy up to his mouth, and let it lick the liquid off his own tongue, corresponding to the way the other dog in the register above is shown drinking from a bowl¹⁵⁶. Here, the tongue has been used in feeding the animal and has no negative symbolism as in previous instances. Moreover, this reflects the intimate contact between human and animals in Ancient Egypt. However, representing the dog touching the mouth of the man may indicate that this person is of low social status¹⁵⁷. The statue and the amulet seem to illustrate the same action¹⁵⁸.

IV.2 The protruding tongue of humans in Ancient Egyptian texts

Interestingly, the indications of the protruding tongue of humans are more frequent in textual sources than in visual ones. Protruding the tongue at deities and humans was a highly hostile gesture and can be used to symbolize insult, threats, offense or Provocation¹⁵⁹. Furthermore, it was a genuine, very serious threat intended to frighten the enemy and prevent them from approaching¹⁶⁰. Among the most significant sources that mention this gesture are the following:

IV.2.1. Kamose Stele I (Cairo TR 11/1/35/1)¹⁶¹, Carnarvon Tablet

The limestone fragments of the first stele of King Kamose, which were discovered in the foundations of the south tower of the third pylon at Karnak¹⁶² and housed in the

¹⁵⁴ Miles 2010, 72; Harpur/Scremin 2006, 377.

¹⁵⁵ Miles 2010, 72-73.

¹⁵⁶ Miles 2010, 73, 75; Evans 107–08; Thiringer 2020, 25-26, 107.

¹⁵⁷ Miles 2010, 81.

¹⁵⁸ Thiringer 2020, 26.

¹⁵⁹ Kurth 1986, 1425.

¹⁶⁰ Meeks 1995, 35, 264.

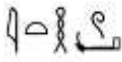
¹⁶¹ <https://thesaurus-linguae-aegyptiae.de/sentence/IBUBdWEwrDicGknfjdiVpRxyj6k>, (accessed 01.10.2025); Lacau 1939, 245-271, pls. XXXVII-XXXVIII; PM, vol. 2: Theban temples, 73.

¹⁶² South wing of the third pylon; two fragments: one found on March 21, 1935, in the fill material; see Chevrier 1935, 111; Lacau 1939, 245; a second already in 1932; See Habachi 1955/56, 199; Smith/Smith 1976, 49; the year is not mentioned in Chevrier 1932, 109-111. Hammad 1955, 198, points out that both fragments were discovered in December 23, 1928; Simpson 2003, 346-348. On the other hand, Montet 1956, 114, mentions the discovery of

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Egyptian Museum in Cairo, report of the king's conflict with the Hyksos. The text of this stela is identical to that of the Carnarvon Tablet I (JE 41790)¹⁶³, which most likely was training of writing skills for young scribes. Despite the scribe's mistakes of this copy on the tablet, it is of great significance as it assists in identifying and complementing the original text inscribed on the fragmented stele¹⁶⁴. The text begins by reporting how Kamose convened a council in the third year of his reign to discuss his plans to expel the Hyksos from Egypt with his consultants. At first, the king expressed his extreme outrage as two rulers in Avaris and Kush were sharing the control of Egypt with him. Then, he expresses his sincere wish to liberate Egypt and destroy the Asiatics. The council initially reacted with fear and mentioned that the conditions in Egypt were peaceful, and there is no need for further concerns¹⁶⁵:

Then the great men of his council said: Behold, the water (i.e., the sphere of influence) of the Asiatics extends as far as Cusae. (and) after they had drawn out their tongues (jth.n .sn ns .sn), they said with one voice: We are comfortable (lit.: pleasantly cool) in our (part of) Egypt. Elephantine is mighty/strong, the middle/center (of the country) is on our side as far as Cusae. The best of her fields is plowed for us. Our cattle (graze) in the delta marshes. Emmer wheat has been sent to our pigs.

The verb jth  does not mean to protrude; herausstrecken, rather to pull (out) (heraus)ziehen¹⁶⁶. It is also used in the context of archery¹⁶⁷ and is one of the divine epithets of the goddess Sekhmet: "she who draws (out) the arrows; die die pfeile herauszieht"¹⁶⁸. This verb in this context refers to the analogy of tongues and arrows and hence, can be interpreted as a hostile and threatening gesture of the Hyksos toward

both fragments in 1933. (<https://thesaurus-linguae-aegyptiae.de/object/SGDCGCEGWJEVZF25SOLMI2O4RI>) (accessed 01.10.2025).

¹⁶³ This tablet was found in 1908 in Asasif in the so-called "Tablet Tomb" near the Valley Temple of Hatshepsut; The Earl of Carnarvon /Carter 1912, 4, 36-37, pls. XXVII-XVIII; PM I:2, 618; Newberry 1913, 117-122; Gardiner 1917, 95-110, pls. XII-XIII; von Beckerath 1964, 205-207; Barta 1975, 287-290; Smith / Smith 1976, 48-76; Kaplony-Heckel 1985, 525-534;

<https://thesaurus-linguae-aegyptiae.de/object/A3JB6GERCJB5HFCKZDARDIO63U?lang=de> (accessed 01.10.2025).

¹⁶⁴ (<https://thesaurus-linguae-aegyptiae.de/object/SGDCGCEGWJEVZF25SOLMI2O4RI>) (accessed 01.10.2025).

¹⁶⁵ Carnarvon /Carter 1912, 36-37; Gardiner 1917, 103.

¹⁶⁶ Wb I, 148 (12-23).

¹⁶⁷ Meeks 2008, 155 (Nr. 555); Schäfer 1931, 94-96; Edfou VI, 235, 9.

¹⁶⁸ LGG I, 626.

the Egyptians. However, other translations have interpreted this part as a sign of taking a deep breath, with no hostile meaning¹⁶⁹.

IV.2.2. pBrooklyn 47.218.84

Further interesting instance is found in in the Late Period papyrus Brooklyn 47.218.84, which informs of myths and legends of the Delta, and particularly in the section describing “The Revolts and The Crimes of Seth”¹⁷⁰. The first part of the text in question is unfortunately damaged, and according to Meeks, it should describe the defeated enemies who, apparently, utter malicious words toward Horus¹⁷¹ and provoked him by protruding their tongues. The text states¹⁷²:

The place of the battle he fought ... speaking ill (??) against him (?), concerning (?) the deserts of the Preeminent Ones. They stuck their tongues out at his father. It is in that desert (where) the mutilation [XVI, 6] was inflicted upon him by their action, and caused that he ascended to heaven after having been thrown into the river by the one who had killed him, floating as far as that I[met?].

IV.2.3. Temple of Kom Ombo

The texts in the Temple of Kom Ombo contained several hymns dedicated to the temple's principal deities, namely Sobek-Re and Horus, as well as descriptions of mythical events. Among these is a text on the walls leading from the court to the second corridor¹⁷³ that mentions the human rebellion against the god Re and how they provoked him. The beginning of the myth is unfortunately missing; however, the events start with the arrival of the sun god Re from Elephantine to seek his enemies in the region of Kom Ombo and take his revenge and destroy them¹⁷⁴. Obviously, this text is related to the myth of with the revolt of the children of Re¹⁷⁵. The text reads¹⁷⁶:

“ [. . Re said] to Thoth: "Let a divine messenger go [seek] these enemies to make a great slaughter... all their troops around them; they all stuck out their tongues against

¹⁶⁹ <https://tla.digital/sentence/IBUBdWEwrDicGknfjdiVpRxyj6k> (accessed 01.10.2025).

¹⁷⁰ Meeks 2008, 306 ; <https://thesaurus-linguae-aegyptiae.de/object/I2IDHFIF6JA5RGNGKH3BJNDANRI> ; <https://elephantine.smb.museum/objects/object.php?o=318181> (accessed 01.10.2025). This papyrus is dated to the beginning of the 26. Dynasty.

¹⁷¹ Meeks 2008, 36, 155 (Nr. 555).

¹⁷² Meeks 2008, 36.

¹⁷³ Gutbub 1973, 106.

¹⁷⁴ Gutbub 1973, 107, 110 (L); Junker 1917, 28.

¹⁷⁵ Gutbub 1973, 110 (L).

¹⁷⁶ Gutbub 1973, 107, 110 (L); Junker 1917, 28.

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their father¹⁷⁷. "... these enemies, so that he may make a slaughter of them, without leaving a single one of them alive..

Then Thoth said to Re: ... all war equipment, his sword in his right hand, equipped with the bow and equipped with arrows, ... he was swifter than the waves in their course, than the hurricane in the east; he was like the flame at the time of the wind, when it reaches the dry stubble; ... enemies the victor in the midst of adversaries (?), lion in the midst of the multitude, his arm is strong, his actions succeed, his heart rejoices in doing what pleases his father."

Sticking out the tongue is utilized in this context to symbolize insult, disrespect and threat toward the god by his enemies. The text clarifies that the deity Haroeris (Hr wr) in his form of Shu successfully defeated the enemies of his father and slaughtered them all.

The same expression $\text{ḳ}3' \text{ ns}$ is mentioned in the same temple in the hymn for Haroeris (Hr wr), which clarifies that Re was aware of the existence of the rebels and sent his messenger to investigate the situation against him, but it seems they noticed the presence of this messenger. Nevertheless, they paid no attention; instead, they provoked, belittled, and threatened to dissuade him from approaching by sticking out their tongues at him, while he was on the riverbank watching them. The messenger returned after that to report their act to Re. Then, the hymn describes designating the mission of destroying the rebels to Haroeris, and his followers. In the end, they achieved a great victory over the rebels who had been sticking their tongues out at his father and eliminated them completely¹⁷⁸:

"his brave ones tear to pieces the enemies who stick out their tongues against their Lord".

The previously mentioned battle against Haroeris (Hr wr) and his father in the temple of Kom Ombo is followed by an indication to the assassination of Osiris by Seth, who is implicitly referred to by the pronoun "he". He and his followers threaten Osiris by performing the particular act of "sticking their tongues out" at him¹⁷⁹.

In addition, the Kom Ombo temple delivers a further instance of the expression $\text{ḳ}3' \text{ ns}$ in the great hymn dedicated to Sobek-Re¹⁸⁰, as follows:

"who disembowels the bodies of those who stick out their tongues ($\text{ḏ} \text{ r } \text{ḥwt}$ (or 'wt) nt nf $\text{ḳ}3' \text{ w ns}$), who drinks the blood of those who cross his path"

¹⁷⁷ Junker 1917, 28 (2).

¹⁷⁸ Gutbub 1973, 110 (L); Meeks 1995, 34-37; Meeks 2008, 307.

¹⁷⁹ Meeks 2008, 306-307.

¹⁸⁰ LGG VII, 607; De Morgan 1894, 60 (col. 11); Gutbub 1973, 110 (L).

Here, the protruding tongue may refer to the death and the relaxation of the jaw muscles of the bodies that Sobek-Re searches and describes the nature of the crocodile that devours the bodies it encounters in the river.

IV.2.4. Bab El Amara Gate at Karnak

Bab El Amara Gate at Karnak is built in the Late Period and completed by Ptolemy III (Euergetes I). It is located south of the Khonsu Temple at Karnak and is covered with various texts and scenes depicting the king with different deities. On the eastern side of the interior, the king is depicted smiting a fallen enemy with a mace¹⁸¹. The text behind the king describes the action illustrated and states in the end:

His tongue is torn out at the beginning of the throat, the one who sticks out his tongue
against the sole Lord¹⁸²

This evidence clearly demonstrates that the gesture of protruding the tongue as an act of provocation, challenge, and insult was directed not only toward deities but also toward kings by their enemies. It is evident that the king responded to this hostile gesture with utmost severity by cutting off the tongue that had been sticking out against him.

V. The protruding tongue and gesture of licking

Another gesture that is closely associated with the protruding tongue is licking (nsb)¹⁸³. Licking of the body is evidenced in ancient Egyptian funerary texts in two distinct contexts. In the first, licking the body during the mummification by a goddess as a mother to her son or the son of the dead as Horus did with Osiris in order to cleanse and heal him as well as to restore his corpse after death. This healing power is symbolized by the saliva, which flows from the mouth to the body and represents the power of rebirth and regeneration. In the second context, however, licking the body is a punishment for sinners. The deceased fears to be licked by a human-skinned demon or by Seth during the judgment of the dead¹⁸⁴. However, few scenes and texts mention or depict the (protruding) tongue as describing the licking. The most significant evidence is as follows:

V.1. Hathor and Hatshepsut at the temple of Deir el-Bahari

This essential role of Hathor is repeatedly documented in the texts and iconography of the Temple of Deir el-Bahri, particularly in the so-called the Shrine of Hathor. Distinguished in this shrine are, however, the scenes depicting her as a cow licking the

¹⁸¹ PM II, 225-227; <https://digitalkarnak.ucsc.edu/bab-el-amara-gate/> (accessed 01.10.2025); Clère 1961, pl. 62.

¹⁸² LGG VII, 174; Clère 1961, pl. 62.

¹⁸³ Wb II, 334 (11-14).

¹⁸⁴ Abbas, E./Abdelwahed 2019, 47-63.

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Queen's hand (fig. 71)¹⁸⁵. Here she licks and kisses Hatshepsut's hand and addresses to her: "I kiss your hand, lick your limbs, and grant your Majesty life and dominion", and in other similar scene: "I kiss your hand, I lick your limbs with my pleasant tongue which has come forth from my mouth, you being born daily on the hands of your father Amon"¹⁸⁶. Although the tongue is not mentioned in the text, it is clearly observed in the figure of the goddess. In addition to previous symbolism of the licking mentioned above, it underscores here the queen's legitimacy through her mother, Hathor. The filiation is evidently emphasized by a text from the same temple, which mentions that Hathor licks Horus, i.e., Thutmose III, whom she has borne. This expression is influenced by observing nature, where cows naturally lick their calves¹⁸⁷.

In Later periods, licking the deceased extended to include private sources, as the papyrus of Tanefer (CG 40014)¹⁸⁸ demonstrates (fig. 72)¹⁸⁹. Hathor is depicted as a cow coming out from the marshes and licks the deceased's arm to ensure his rebirth and regeneration¹⁹⁰.

V.2. The Papyrus of the scribe Nesmin and the Papyrus of Djed-Hor

The late-period Papyrus of the scribe Nesmin in the British Museum (EA10208,1)¹⁹¹ and the late-period Papyrus of Djed-Hor in the Louvre (pLouvre N. 3079)¹⁹² contain a similar significant textual reference to licking with the protruding tongue. The text, which contains a ritual of the transfiguration of Osiris, states:

"[Perfect are your eyebrows] (and) your [beard] shines with radiant brilliance, Osiris Chontamenti!...Perfect are your two lips, sharp your teeth of turquoise, Osiris

¹⁸⁵ <https://www.flickr.com/photos/manna4u/9018888204/> (accessed 01.10.2025); Naville 1901, Pl. XCIV; Ritner 1993, 93.

¹⁸⁶ Ritner 1993, 93.

¹⁸⁷ Ritner 1993, 93.

¹⁸⁸ <https://totenbuch.awk.nrw.de/objekt/tm134465> (accessed 01.10.2025).

¹⁸⁹ <https://www.ushabtis.com/cairo-81-bd-s-r-vii-10244-je-33997/> (accessed 01.10.2025).

¹⁹⁰ Ritner 1993, 93.

¹⁹¹ Haikal II 1972, 52, 59 (20); <https://tla.digital/sentence/IBUBdQf91uevz0TmjHqWj9I7TIU> ; <https://tla.digital/object/GRWDACN6MRGPHMW6GGWPGMPDLE> ; <https://tla.digital/object/JCMC4JU24RGZDE23YLAB3O3YNY> ; <https://tla.digital/text/F35B4R63DRB5RNEEBEO6QAPKUA/sentences?page=5#sentence-49>

¹⁹² <https://thesaurus-linguae-aegyptiae.de/object/YNFF253HXNC3DNJ5OEGUYUCJQI> ; <https://thesaurus-linguae-aegyptiae.de/sentence/IBUBd4PwmxxXtk4Eksm6ippBow0?lang=en> ; <https://collections.louvre.fr/en/ark:/53355/cl010378275>

Chontamenti!..."Perfect is your tongue as leader of the two lands, which licks your enemies ("will annihilate your enemies"), Osiris Chontamenti!" 193

The licking here is associated with the enemies, what has most likely a destructive effect on them. Haikal suggests that the purpose of the tongue licking the enemies is annihilating them by destroying their names written on papyri. She supports her interpretation by citing another text in which the verb lick off is used to erase a freshly written inscription and arguments that the texts of Nesmin and Djed-Hor have the same meaning¹⁹⁴. Thus, the tongue is used as a kind of weapon to metaphorically destroy the enemies.

VI. Conclusion

In summary it can be stated that gestures played a pivotal role in ancient Egypt as a means of nonverbal communication. They enabled even those who cannot read to comprehend the depicted actions, feelings, and messages. Thus, gestures were a significant tool for conveying content visually and directly, without the need for explanatory text. One of the most frequently depicted gestures is the protruding tongue, which has been documented in various contexts with different meanings and symbolisms according to the context. There are direct and indirect indications of the protruding tongue, either through textual descriptions or symbolic representations in the iconographic representations, as it was not a random but a deliberate detail.

In depictions of cattle, the protruding tongues can signify various meanings, such as loud sounds in daily life scenes, profound suffering during birth, pain and panic in slaughter or hunting scenes, death of slaughtered animals, joyful sounds of young calves, domestication of animals, or motherhood. Moreover, it can reflect the natural behavior of animals while eating or drinking, what demonstrates a high level of observation of the artist. Interestingly, the protruding tongue was employed to refer to the human voice of the anthropomorphizing animals during talking and singing. This feature is used to convey the concept to the viewer and to emphasize the humanization of the animal, indicating to their ability to speak like humans, although human figures themselves aren't illustrated with protruding tongue to refer to their voice during talking or singing.

On the divine level, the protruding tongue was used frequently to symbolize the apotropaic, loud sound of some divine creatures, deities or demons, essentially for protection and to frighten and drive away the evil spirits or harmful creatures. In addition, it reflects ferocity and outrage of some deities as well.

¹⁹³ <https://thesaurus-linguae-aegyptiae.de/sentence/IBUBd4PwmxxXtk4Eksm6ippBow0-?lang=en>; Completion after: pMMA 35.9.21 (20,1-2) and pLouvre I. 3079 (110,34).

¹⁹⁴ Haikal II 1972, 59 (20).

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In representations of humans, the protruding tongue is less common than in animals, yet they are described more frequently in textual sources. They symbolize provocation, insult, mockery, or defiance, whether directed at other individuals, rulers or at deities. Remarkably, the evidence in human sources is usually associated with enemies. Although there is no visual evidence of cutting off protruding tongues as a punishment, there are cases where foes sticking out their tongues while falling or kneeling under the king's feet/chariot or hit by his arrows or being attacked by Egyptian soldiers. The protruding tongues here emphasize humiliation and severe pain. This may suggest that the ancient Egyptians used the protruding tongue to symbolize the lower status of the enemies, much like animals. This observation suggests that, in contrast to animal behavior, the Ancient Egyptians did not utilize protruding tongues for humans as a means of expressing voice, pain, or speech. In these contexts, the loud voices are represented either by a wide-open mouth or even pursed lips.

Finally, textual sources indicate that sticking out the tongue was likened to dangers weapons, such as arrows and knives, and therefore, sticking out the tongue was regarded as an extremely dangerous hostile act in Ancient Egypt. Furthermore, it carries connotations of mockery, threat, and defiance. This is evident in the Hyksos sticking out their tongues against the Egyptians, and in the rebels and enemies protruding their tongues against Re, Osiris, Horus, and Re's envoy who went to investigate the situation among the rebels. On the other hand, the texts demonstrate the severe punishment inflicted by the deities and kings upon those who stuck out their tongues against them, as they defeated them decisively and, in some cases, cut out this tongue that they dared to stick out. On the other hand, the protruding tongue was associated with the act of licking, and this gesture, along with the saliva accompanying it, deliver contradictory symbolism according to the context, such as healing or harm.

In conclusion, by examining these sources and noting the significant diversity in the use and symbolism of the protruding tongue, it becomes clear that this gesture held meaningful functions in non-verbal communication and that its significance continued throughout Ancient Egyptian history until the Greco-Roman period.

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Figures



Fig. 1: Scene from the tomb of Niankhnesut, 6. Dynasty, The Detroit Institute of Arts.

After: Arnold 1999, no. 193, 471.



Fig. 2: Scene from the tomb of Ankhmahor, 6. Dynasty, Saqqara.

After: Kanawati 1997, pl. 37.

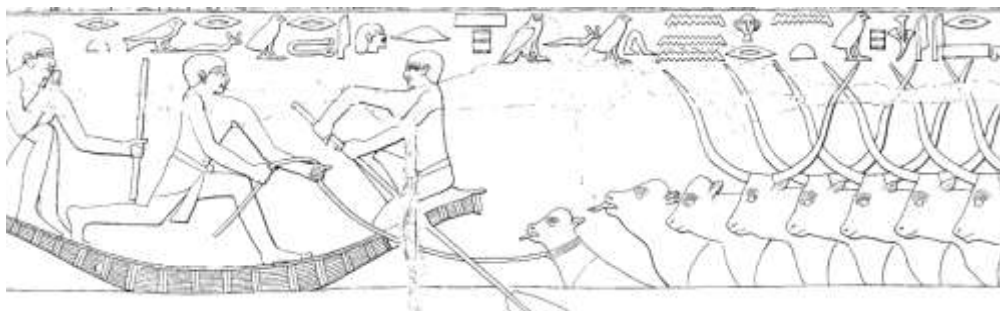


Fig. 3: Scene from the tomb of Mereruka, 6. Dynasty, Saqqara.

After: Duell 1938, pl. 21.

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Fig. 4: Scene from the tomb of Kagemni, 6. Dynasty, Saqqara.

After: Photo of the author



Fig. 5: Scene from the tomb of Princess Idut, 5.-6. Dynasty, Saqqara.

After: <https://www.flickr.com/photos/manna4u/27427255562/in/photostream/> (accessed on 01.10.2025).



Fig. 6: Scene from the tomb of Tjetu, 4. Dynasty, Giza.

After: Simpson 1980, fig. 22



Fig. 7: Scene from the tomb of Iasen, 4. Dynasty, Giza.

After: Simpson 1980, fig. 30

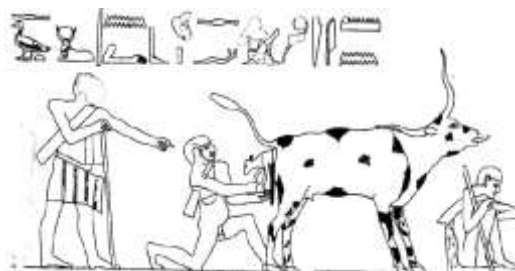


Fig. 8: Scene from the tomb of Senebi, Meir
After: Blackman 1914a, pl. X.



Fig. 9: Scene from the tomb of Ti, 5.
Dynasty, Saqqara.
After: Wild 1966, pl. CXXIV.



Fig. 10: Scene from the tomb of Niankhkhnum and Khnumhotep, 5. Dynasty, Saqqara.
After: <https://www.flickr.com/photos/manna4u/5241284757/in/photostream/> (accessed on 01.10.2025)



Fig. 11: Scene from the tomb of Ti, 5. Dynasty, Saqqara.
After: Wild 1966, pl. CXXIV.

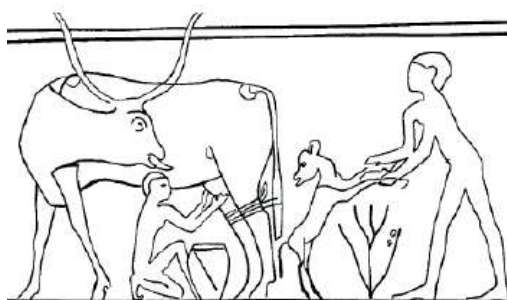


Fig. 12: Scene from the tomb of Akh-merwt-niswt, 5.
Dynasty, Giza.
After: Smith 1949, 208, fig. 79.



Fig. 13: Scene from the tomb of Kagemni, 6. Dynasty,
Saqqara.
After: Photo of the author

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Fig. 14: Scene from the tomb of Ptahhotep, 6. Dynasty, Saqqara.
After: Davies 1901, pl. XVII.

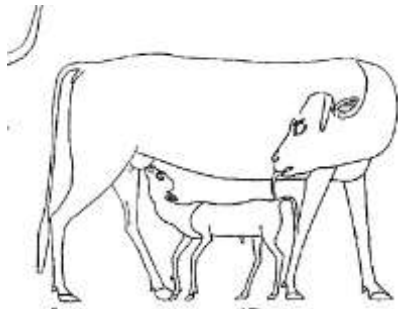


Fig. 15: Scene from the tomb of Akhethotep (B-2), 12. Dynasty, Saqqara.
After: Blackman 1914b, pl. VII.

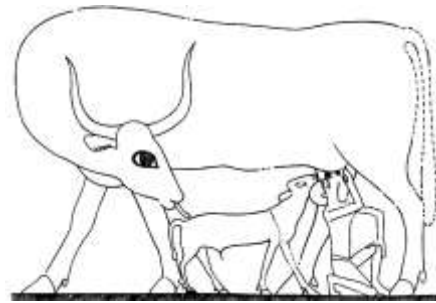


Fig. 16: Scene from the tomb of Baqet III (No. 15), 11. Dynasty, Beni Hassan.
After: Davies 1933, fig. 10.



Fig. 17: Scene from the tomb of Queen Aashyt, 11. Dynasty, Egyptian Museum in Cairo.
After: Photo of the author

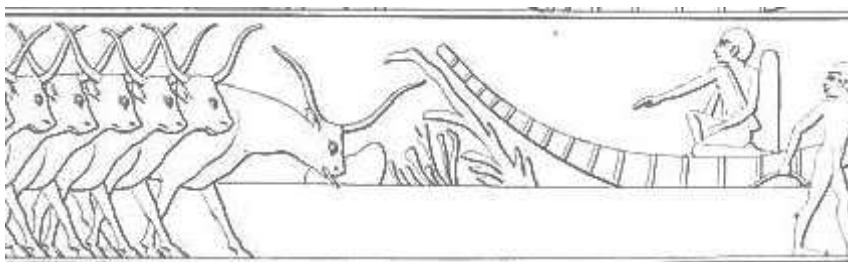


Fig. 18: Scene from the tomb of Nebemakhet (No. 86), 4. Dynasty, Giza.
After: LD II, pl. 12.



Fig. 19: Scene from the tomb of Ti, 5. Dynasty, Saqqara.

After: Photo of the author



Fig. 20: Scene from the tomb of Niankhkhnum and Khnumhotep, 5. Dynasty, Saqqara.

After:

<https://www.flickr.com/photos/manna4u/5241867530/in/photostream/> (accessed on 01.10.2025).

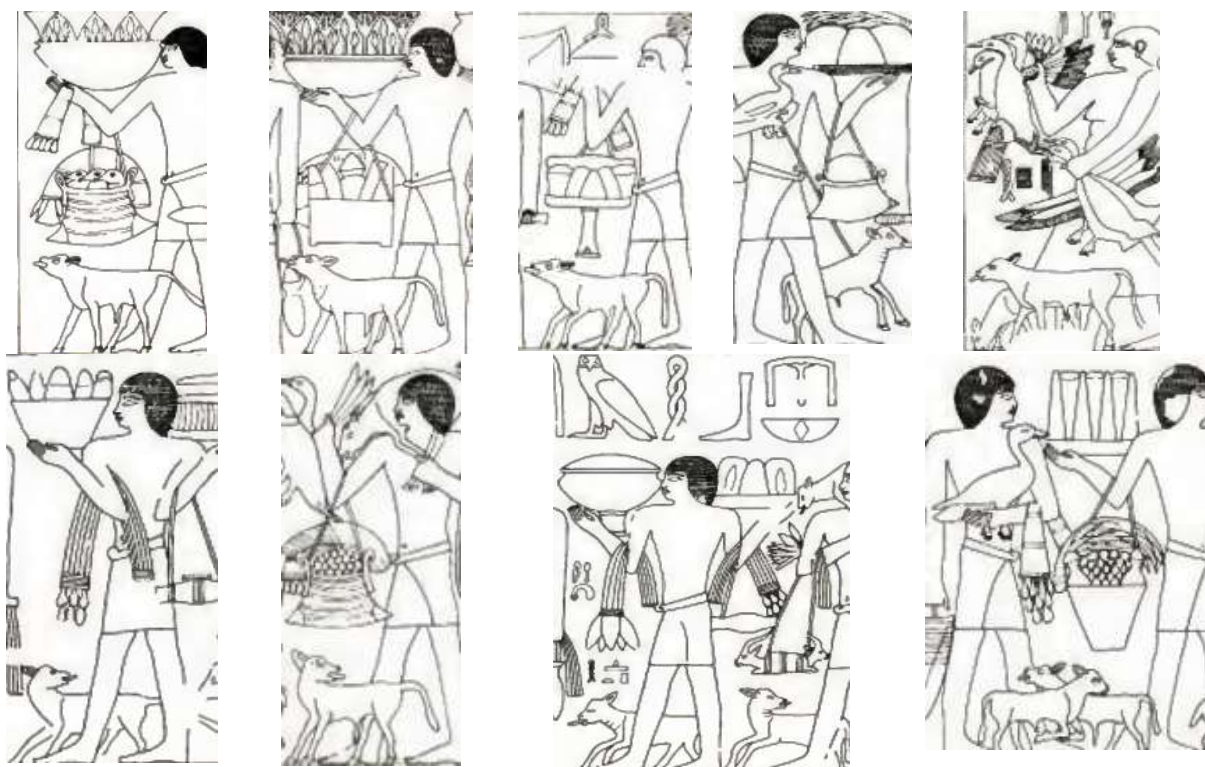


Fig. 21: Details from offering bearers scene from the tomb of Ankhmahor, 6. Dynasty, Saqqara.

After: Kanawati 1997, pls. 47-51.



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Fig. 22: Details from offering bearers scene from the tomb of Ankhmahor, 6. Dynasty, Saqqara.
After: Kanawati 1997, pl. 49.



Fig. 23: Details from Opet-festival procession of Ramses II, 19. Dynasty, Thebes.

After: <https://www.flickr.com/photos/manna4u/22984052603/> ;
<https://www.flickr.com/photos/manna4u/23315357940/in/photostream/> (accessed 01.10.2025)



Fig. 24: well-fed animals are led to the slaughterhouse of the temple, 20. Dynasty, Medinet Habu

After: Medinet Habu III, OIP 23, pl. 173.

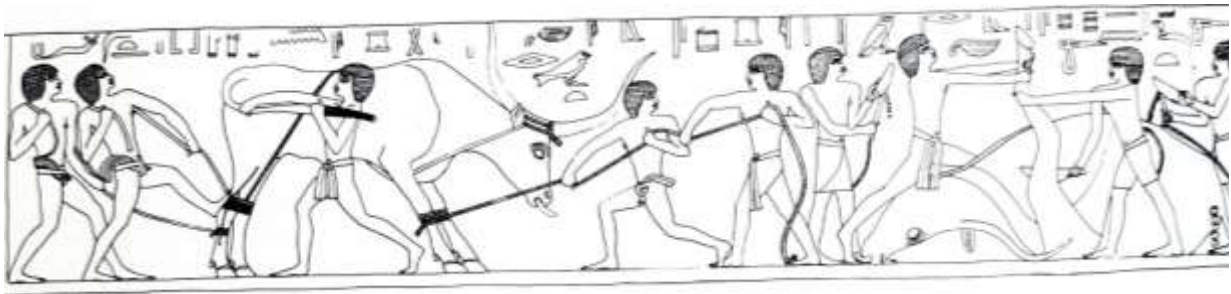


Fig. 25: Details from slaughter scene from the tomb of Hetepka, 5. Dynasty, Saqqara.

After: Martin 1979, pl. 13.



Fig. 26: Scene from the tomb of Senebi, Meir

After: Blackman 1914a, pl. XI.

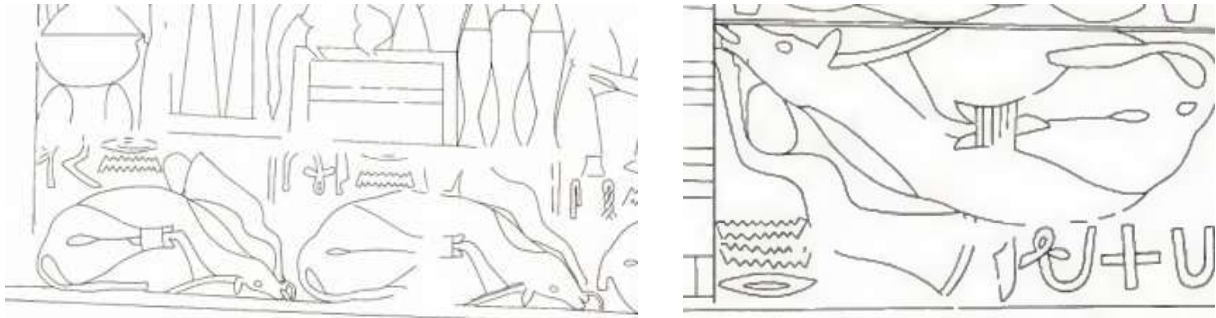


Fig. 27: Details from offering scenes from the tomb of Ankhmahor, 6. Dynasty, Saqqara.
After: Kanawati 1997, pls. 62-64.



Fig. 28: Ramses III. dedicates slaughtered cattle to the Theban triad, 20. Dynasty, Medinet Habu
After: Medinet Habu III, OIP 23, pl. 179.



Fig. 29: Detail from slaughtering scene, 20. Dynasty, Medinet Habu
After: Medinet Habu III, OIP 23, pl. 173.



Fig. 30: Detail from slaughtering scene from the tomb of Ramose, 18. Dynasty, Thebes
After: Davies 1941, pl. XIII.

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Fig. 31: Ramses III. hunts wilds bulls, 20. Dynasty, Medinet Habu
After: Medinet Habu II, OIP 9, pl. 117.



Fig. 32: Cat with protruding tongue tied to a chair, 18. Dynasty, tomb of May (TT 130)
After: Malek 2006, 63.



Fig. 33: Cat with protruding tongue under a chair, 18. Dynasty, Tomb of Nebamun and Ipuky (TT 181)
After: Davies 1936, pl. LXI.



Fig. 34: Satiric scene on a Limestone ostrakon, 19. Dynasty, Ashmolean Museum (AN1942.53).
After: Babcock 2022, 112.



Fig. 35: Satiric scene on a Limestone ostrakon, Princeton University Art Museum.
After: Babcock 2022, 148.

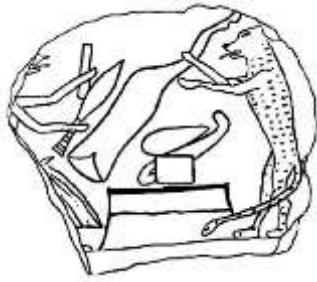


Fig. 36: Satiric scene on a Limestone ostrakon, unknown location.

After: Babcock 2022, 138



Fig. 37: The cat of Heliopolis slaughters the Apophis serpent, 19. Dynasty, tomb of Inherkhau (TT 359).

After: Photo of the author

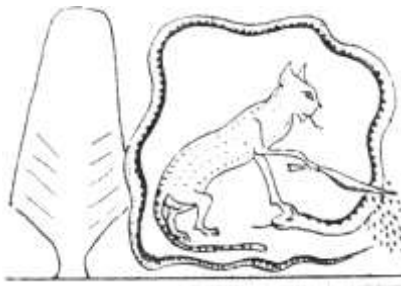


Fig. 38: The cat of Heliopolis slaughters the Apophis serpent, 19. Dynasty, P. Dublin MS 1661.

After: Naville 1886, pl. XXX.



Fig. 39: Tefnut and Thot on an ostrakon, 19. Dynasty, Berlin (Inv. ÄM 21443)

After: Babcock 2023, 23; Babcock 2022, 168.



Fig. 40: Tutankhamun hunts lions on the lid of his casket, 18. Dynasty, GEM

After: Davis 1936, pl. LXXVII

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Fig. 41: Ramses III hunts lions, 20. Dynasty, Medinet Habu
After: Medinet Habu I, OIP 8, pl. 35.



Fig. 42: Tutankhamun shooting arrows at waterfowl on his golden shrine, 18. Dynasty, GEM
After: Bailleul-LeSuer 2016, 620.

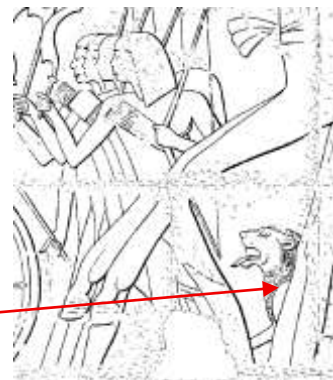
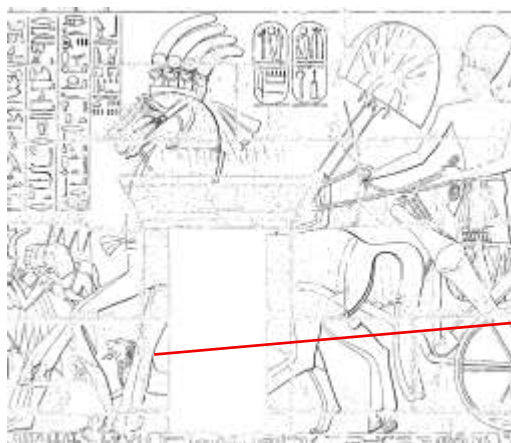


Fig. 43: Details from a scene representing Ramses III. marshing against Libyan, 20. Dynasty, Medinet Habu
After: Medinet Habu I, OIP 8, pl. 17.



Fig. 44: Details from a scene representing Ramses III. returning from Libyan campaign, 20. Dynasty, Medinet Habu
After: Medinet Habu II, OIP 9, pl. 77.



Fig. 45: A cosmetic jar of Tutankhamun, 18. Dynasty, GEM
After: Manniche 2019, pls. XXXIII-XXXIII



Fig. 46: A cosmetic jar of Tutankhamun, 18. Dynasty, GEM
After: Manniche 2019, pls. XXVIII- XXXI.

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Fig. 47: Bes on the bed of Tutankhamun, 18. Dynasty, GEM
After: https://ancienegypte.fr/2musee_caire2018/page8.htm (accessed 01.10.2025)



Fig. 48: Colored reconstruction of the anthropomorphized animals as musician on Pap. 55001, Egyptian Museum in Turin, 19. Dynasty, from Deir el-Medina
After: Omlin 1973, pl. XIV



Fig. 49: Vignette from Pap. of Nespaheran, Skrine pa. No. 2, 21.-22. Dyn., Oxford
After: Blackman 1918, pl. III.



Fig. 50: Vignette from Pap. of Nespaheran, Skrine pa. No. 2, 21.-22. Dyn., Oxford
After: Blackman 1918, pl. V.



Fig. 51: Scene from the tomb of Hetepka, 5. Dynasty, Saqqara.

After: Martin 1979, pl. 10; Harpur 1987 fig. 42.



Fig. 52: Ramses III. hunts desert animals, 20. Dynasty, Medinet Habu

After: Medinet Habu II, OIP 9, pl. 116.



Fig. 53: Hunting Hippo from the tomb of Ti, 5. Dynasty, Saqqara

After:

<https://www.flickr.com/photos/manna4u/44522545732/>
(accessed 01.10.2025)



Fig. 54: Scene from the tomb of Princess Idut, 5.-6. Dynasty, Saqqara.

After: <https://www.flickr.com/photos/manna4u/26917648383/in/photostream/> (accessed 01.10.2025)

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Fig. 55: Scene from the tomb of Princess Idut, 5.-6. Dynasty, Saqqara.

After: <https://www.flickr.com/photos/mana4u/27427089152/> (accessed 01.10.2025)



Fig. 56: Statue of Taweret, Late Period.

After:
Wilkinson 2007, 185.



Fig. 57: Chapter BD 137, Pap. Of Ani, 19. Dynasty, London.

After:
https://www.britishmuseum.org/collection/object/Y_EA10470-37
(accessed 01.10.2025)



Fig. 58: Ammit on the bed of Tutankhamun, 18. Dynasty, GEM.

After:
<https://www.flickr.com/photos/mana4u/26954783462/in/photostream/> (accessed 01.10.2025).

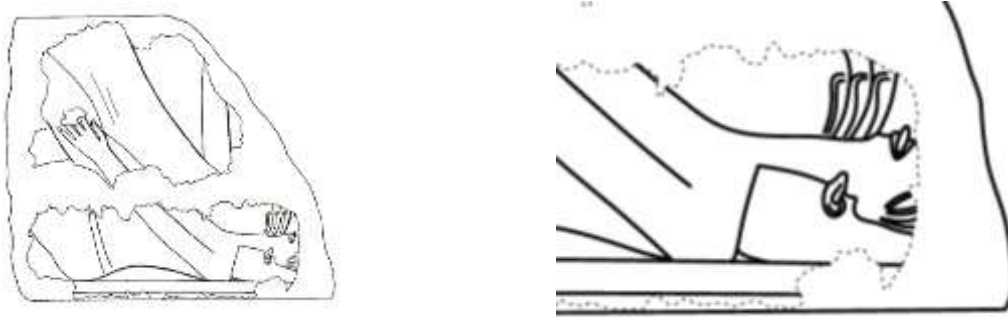


Fig. 59: Scene from the mortuary temple of Pepi II, 06. Dynasty, saqqaara.
After: Jéquier 1940, vol. III, pl. 18.



Fig. 61: Detail from the casket of Tutankhamun, 18. Dynasty, GEM
After: Photo of the author

Fig. 60: Scene of Syrian chiefs from the tomb of an unknown official (TT 58), 18. Dynasty, Thebes.
After: Davis 1936, pl. LX, vol III, 115.

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Fig. 62: Detail from the casket of Tutankhamun, 18. Dynasty, GEM
After: Hawass/Vannini 2008, 25.



Fig. 63: Detail from the casket of Tutankhamun, 18. Dynasty, GEM
After: Hawass/Vannini 2008, 25.



Fig. 64: A fragment of a sculptor's model shows a Syrian with his tongue sticking out and his nose cut off, Late Period (?).
After: Keimer 1954, Tf. XIV.



Fig. 65: Relief of Bes, Dendera, Roman Period.
After: Wilkinson 2007, 104.



Fig. 68: Scene from the tomb of Kagemni, 6. Dynasty, Saqqara.

After: <https://www.flickr.com/photos/manna4u/page43> (accessed 01.10.2025)

Fig. 66: Headrest of Tutaankhamun, 18. Dynasty, GEM.

Fig. 67: Detail from chariot A 2 of Tutaankhamun, 18. Dynasty, GEM.

After:

<https://www.globalegyptianmuseum.org/detail.aspx?id=15074> (accessed 01.10.2025)

After:

<https://www.flickr.com/photos/sandrovannini/4250080981/in/photostream/> (accessed 01.10.2025)

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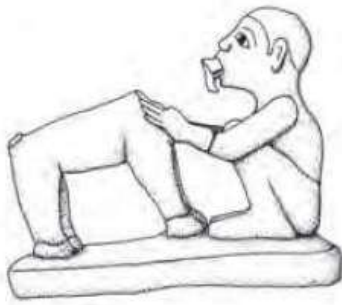


Fig. 69: Statuette of a man with a dog (JE 72143), Giza (G 7715 a), 6. Dyn.

After: Miles 2010,73, fig. 2.



Fig. 70: Amulet (UC 38150), unknown province, 6. Dyn.

After: Miles 2010,73, fig. 3.



Fig. 71: Hathor licks the hand of Hatshepsut (cartouche modified to Thutmose II), Deir el Bahari, 18. Dyn.

After:

<https://www.flickr.com/photos/mana4u/9018888204/>
(accessed 01.10.2025)



Fig. 72: Hathor licks the deceased, Tanefer (CG 40014), 21. Dynasty

After: <https://www.ushabtis.com/cairo-81-bd-s-r-vii-10244-je-33997/> (accessed 01.10.2025)